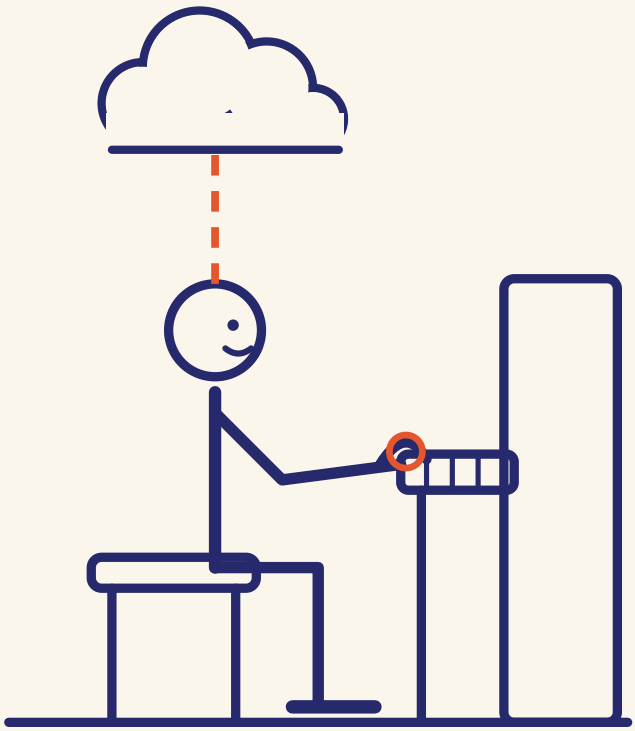
CHAPTER 1

# Posture & Hand Shape



Before the first note: how to sit, and how to hold your hands. Get these right, and every note after them is easier.

## In this chapter


| | |
|---|---|
| Sit at the piano | page 2 |
| Let the arm carry the hand | page 3 |
| A round hand | page 4 |
| Finger numbers | page 5 |
| Play: finger walks | page 6 |
| My five checks | page 7 |


## By the end, you can

- [ ] sit at the right height and distance
- [ ] move your hand with the whole arm
- [ ] make a round hand and play on the tips
- [ ] say every finger number, on both hands

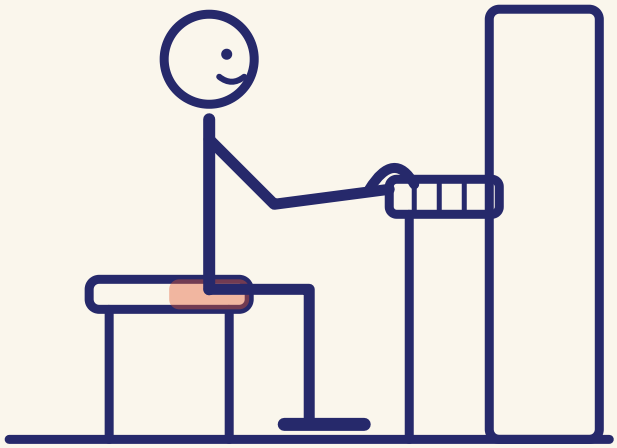
Goes with: Workbook pages 3 to 7, and the online lesson (scan the code below).

**TEACHER** This chapter is the base for every other one. For the first few weeks, start every lesson with the five checks on page 7. draft Teacher strips are a first draft: rewrite them in your own words.

Try it in the app

Step 1 · Workbook page 3

# Sit at the piano

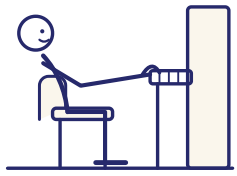


Two things to set: **how high** and **how far**. Your forearm is level with the keys, and your elbows sit just in front of your body.

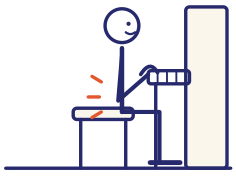
## At the piano

1. Sit on the **front half of the stool**, feet flat on the floor. ☐
2. Raise or lower the stool until your **forearm is level** with the keys. ☐
3. Slide in or out until your **elbows are just in front of you**, about a fist away from your sides. ☐

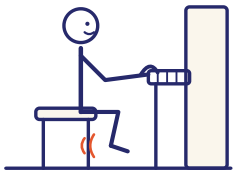
**Not like this**



× Leaning back, like on a sofa



× So close the elbows squash in



× Feet swinging in the air

**REMEMBER** **Front half of the stool, feet flat, sit tall.**

**TEACHER** Watch for elbows squashed in (too close) or arms reaching out (too far). Feet dangling? A footstool or a sturdy box fixes it. Say: "Sit tall, like a puppet on a string."

Step 2 · Workbook page 3

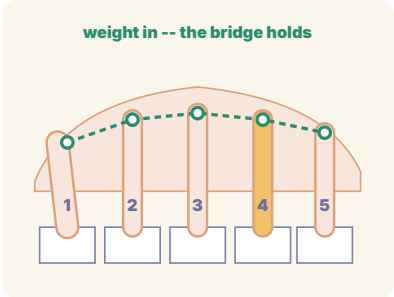
# Let the arm carry the hand

Fingers press the keys, but the **arm** takes the hand where it needs to go. These warm-ups take a few minutes at the start of practice.



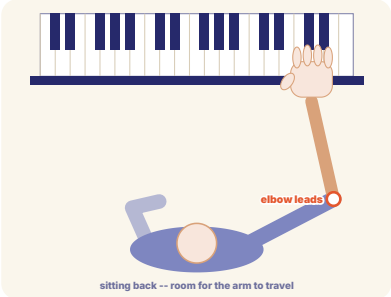

## Rag doll

Let both arms hang heavy and shake them loose. Then float the hands up to the keys.



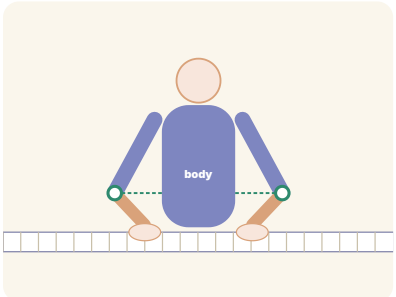

## Knuckle bridge

Fingertips resting on five keys. Press one key slowly down and hold for 3. Knuckles stay up.



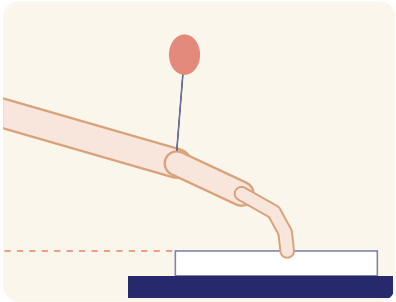

## Arm glide

Carry the round hand up the piano to the next group of keys. The fingers ride, they don't walk.



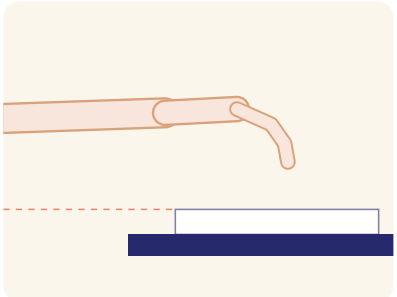

## Elbow wings

Hands still on the keys, let the elbows float out to the side and back.



## Wrist balloon

A balloon tied to the wrist lifts it up, then it floats back down to level.



## Arm drop

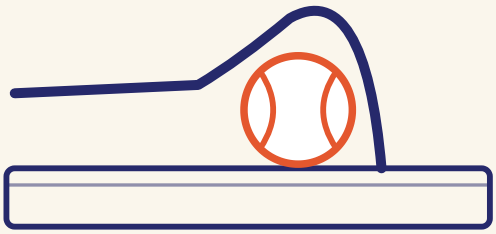
Lift the whole arm and let it drop into a key on finger 3: firm tip, soft wrist.

**REMEMBER** B7 **Let the arm feel heavy, then let that weight rest on the keys.**

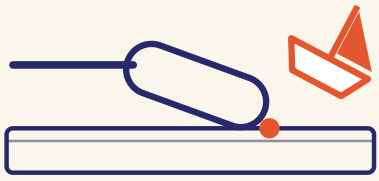
**TEACHER** Two or three warm-ups each lesson is plenty; rotate them over the week. Say: "Arms heavy, like wet spaghetti. Now rest them on the keys."

Step 3 · Workbook page 4

# A round hand



Round, like holding a ball



The thumb: on its side corner

Let your arms hang, then lift your hands as if you were holding a small ball. Keep that shape when the hand goes on the keys. **Knuckles up** like a bridge, B4 **wrist level** with your forearm, and play on the **fingertips**.

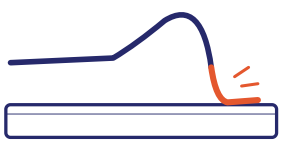
## At the piano

1. Hands on your knees. Hold an imaginary ball. ☐
2. Move the ball shape onto the keys without squashing it. ☐
3. Play one key with each finger, on the tip. The knuckles stay up. ☐

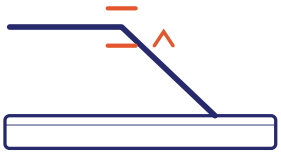
**Not like this**



× Flat fingers



× Tip joint caving in



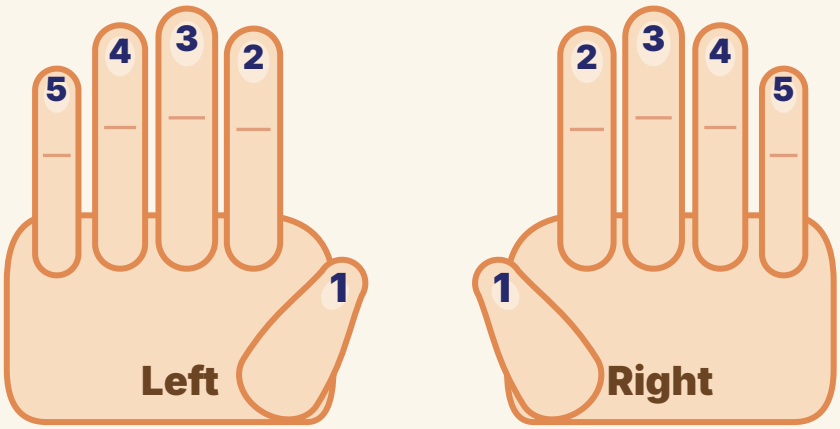
× Wrist stiff and high

**REMEMBER** **Round fingers, like holding a ball. Play on the tips.**

**TEACHER** Watch the tip joint, especially on finger 5: it must not cave in. Say: "Hold a little bubble in your hand. Don't pop it!"

Step 4 · Workbook pages 4 and 5

# Finger numbers




Every finger has a number, **1 to 5, starting from the thumb**. It's the same on both hands: both thumbs are 1, and both little fingers are 5.

B5 **1 Captain Thumb** · **2 Pointer** · **3 Tall Middle** · **4 Shy Ring** · **5 Baby Pinky**

## The mirror game

1. Hold both hands up. Wiggle each finger as you say its number. ☐
2. Your teacher calls "Right hand, 3!" and you wiggle it. Try ten calls. ☐
3. Swap: you call the finger, and your teacher wiggles it. ☐

**REMEMBER** **Fingers are numbered 1 to 5 from the thumb, on both hands.**

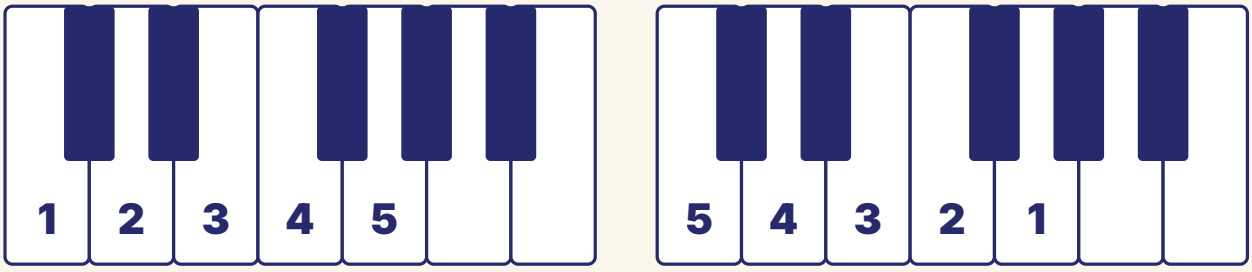
**TEACHER** Watch for the left hand numbered from the little finger. Say: "Thumbs are always 1. Your hands are mirror twins."

Try it in the app

Play

# Finger walks

Now put it together: sit well, make a round hand, and walk your fingers. **One circle is one steady beat.** Say the numbers out loud as you play. Your teacher shows you where to put your hand.




## Stairs and slide

up the stairs, then down the slide

1 2 3 4 5 | 5 4 3 2 1

## Hop on 3

an arm drop on every 3

3 ○ 3 ○ | 3 3 3 ○

## Neighbours

two fingers next door, taking turns

1 2 1 2 | 2 3 2 3 | 3 4 3 4 | 4 5 4 5 | 5 ○

An empty dashed circle means: hold the note for one more beat.

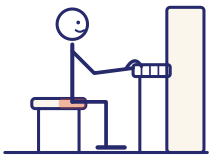
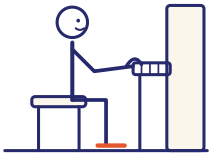
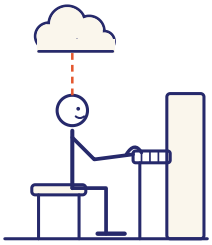
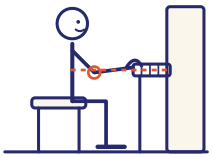
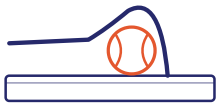
**REMEMBER** **The same round hand on every note.**

**TEACHER** Right hand first, then left hand, then together if it is easy. Watch the hand shape, not the speed. Any five white keys near the middle will do; the letter names come in chapter 3.

Step 5 · Workbook pages 6 and 7

# My five checks

Before you play, every time. Give yourself a star for each check in each lesson.

| | Lesson 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 | 6 |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
|  **Front half of the stool** | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ |
|  **Feet flat on the floor** | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ |
|  **Sit tall, like a puppet on a string** | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ |
|  **B3 Forearm level with the keys** | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ |
|  **Round hand, play on the tips** | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ |

**REMEMBER** **Check your posture before every practice.**

**TEACHER** At the start of each lesson, the student says the five checks out loud while doing them; you only correct. When all five are easy, do the Chapter check-up on Workbook page 7.